

Food & Nutrition Security UPDATE

May 2026

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KEY MESSAGES

- Global food and nutrition insecurity is increasing despite broadly stable supplies of major staples. Since the last update in March, agricultural and cereal price indices have risen by 3 and 4 percent, respectively. Conflict and climate shocks continue to be the primary drivers of acute food insecurity. Up to [67 million people](#) in need of food assistance in East and Southern Africa, with 14 localities considered at risk of famine in [Sudan](#), and nearly [52.9 million people](#) are projected to be acutely food insecure in West and Central Africa during the June to August 2026 lean season.
- The Middle East conflict is increasing risks to food security. Disruptions to oil, gas and fertilizer flows through the Strait of Hormuz drove a 46 percent month-on-month rise in urea prices and increased agricultural price indices by 8 percent, raising the risk of an affordability crisis. The [World Bank Commodity Markets Outlook](#) projects that fertilizer prices will rise by 31 percent on average in 2026, reaching their least affordable levels since 2022.
- A 61 to 87 percent probability of El Niño emerging by mid-2026 and continuing into 2027 could make the situation worse by threatening crop production in South Asia, Southern Africa, and parts of East Asia, with rice output potentially falling by 20 to 50 percent.

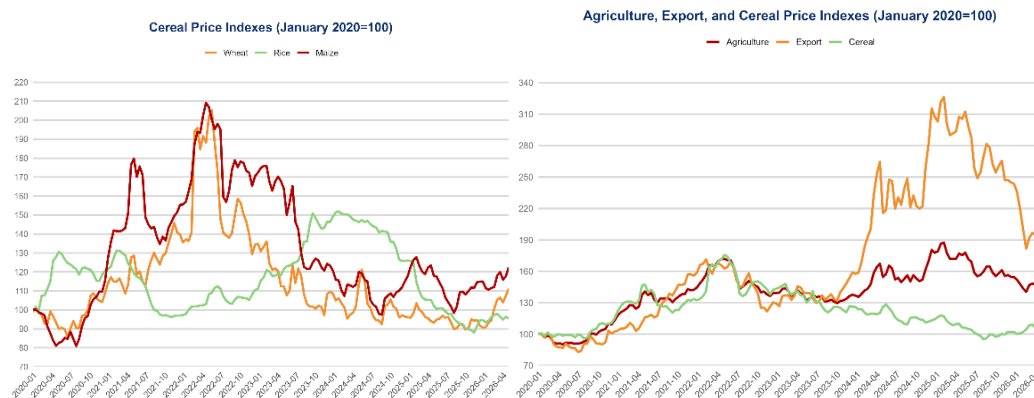
GLOBAL MARKETS OUTLOOK (as of May 22, 2026)

Trends in Global Agricultural Commodity Prices

Since the last update in March, agricultural and cereal prices indices have increased by 3 and 4 percent, respectively, while the export price index has decreased by 4 percent. Maize and wheat prices, which closed 5 and 11 percent higher, respectively, are driving the increase in the cereal price index, and rice prices closed 5 percent lower. On a year-on-year basis, average prices for wheat and maize are 19 and 5 percent higher, respectively, and rice prices are 6 percent lower. Maize and wheat prices are 23 and 18 percent higher, respectively, than in January 2020, and rice prices are 6 percent lower (Figure 1).

The ongoing Middle East conflict has been a key driver of fertilizer market volatility. [Fertilizer price pressures intensified from February through April 2026](#), with urea surging over 80 percent amid regional conflict-driven supply disruptions, while DAP and TSP fertilizers rose approximately 16 and 23 percent, respectively, reflecting the cumulative impact of energy cost pass-throughs and trade route uncertainty. Potash and phosphate rock prices showed no movement, consistent with their insulation from the geopolitical and energy dynamics that have driven nitrogen and phosphate fertilizer market volatility.

Figure 1: Cereal and Agricultural and Price Indexes

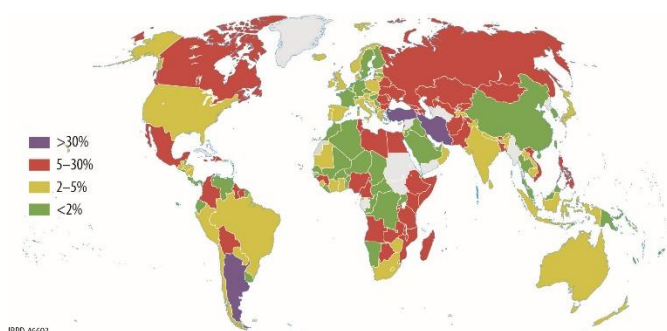


Source: World Bank commodity price data.

Food Price Inflation

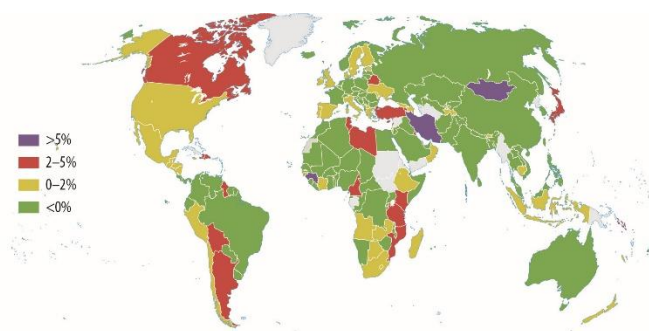
Domestic food price inflation remained moderately high between January and March 2026, with pronounced disparities between countries. Data for this period indicates a slight deterioration in low-income countries, resulting in a higher share of countries with food inflation above 5 percent (40.0 percent to 45.0 percent). On the other hand, conditions improved in lower-middle-income countries (from 40.8 percent to 36.7 percent), upper-middle-income countries (from 34.0 percent to 29.8 percent), and high-income countries (from 6.8 percent to 5.1 percent) (Figure 2a). Regional patterns were similarly uneven. Latin America and the Caribbean and South Asia experienced an increase in food inflation, whereas Europe and Central Asia and parts of Africa generally saw moderate increases, although several countries in Eastern and Southern Africa continued to record double-digit food inflation. In real terms, food price inflation outpaced overall inflation (based on year-on-year changes in the overall Consumer Price Index [CPI]) in 14 percent of the 148 countries for which quarterly food CPI and overall CPI indexes are both available (Figure 2b), underscoring pressure on household purchasing power in those countries.

Figure 2a: Food Inflation Heat Map



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Figure 2b: Real Food Inflation Heat Map



Source: International Monetary Fund, Haver Analytics and Trading Economics. Real food inflation is defined as food inflation minus overall inflation.

Trends in Global Food and Nutrition Security

Global food and nutrition security is under mounting pressure. Supplies of major staples have remained relatively stable, but geopolitical shocks are intensifying. Their full impact on food prices, hunger and nutrition

outcomes is still unfolding. The closure of the Strait of Hormuz has emerged as the defining market event of the period, triggering the largest commodity supply disruption on record.

The [World Bank Commodity Markets Outlook \(April 2026\)](#) projects that fertilizer prices will rise 31 percent on average in 2026—deteriorating to the worst affordability levels since 2022—and the food price index is expected to increase by around 2 percent, with grains up 4 percent and oils and meals up 8 percent. [The AMIS Market Monitor \(May 2026\)](#) notes that the International Grains Council Grains and Oilseeds Index reached a near two-year high in April, with wheat, maize, rice, and soybeans all trending upward, although global supply fundamentals remain relatively strong, including record rice production and broadly stable maize stocks. An emerging El Niño—with a 61 to 87 percent probability of developing by mid-2026 and persisting into 2027—poses a further medium-term risk to crop production in South Asia, Southern Africa, and Australia.

REGIONAL UPDATES

East and Southern Africa

In East and Southern Africa, conflict and climate events continue to drive food insecurity, with up to [67 million people](#) in need of food assistance. [In Sudan, 14 localities are considered at risk of famine](#), and the situation is expected to worsen during the June to September lean season, compounded by atypically early depletion of food stocks, rising food prices, and closure of the Chadian border since February 2026. [In the Democratic Republic of Congo](#), a rare Ebola strain has already caused dozens of deaths and hundreds of suspected and confirmed cases and is colliding with widespread food insecurity. The health crisis comes at a particularly dangerous moment in DRC: 26.5 million people countrywide are already facing acute food insecurity, with needs far outpacing the response. In [South Sudan](#), 9 million people need food assistance, with Emergency outcomes expected across 34 counties through September amid conflict, flooding, and restricted humanitarian access. Climate compounds these crises. In [Somalia](#), there is high concern that conditions of risk of famine may be reached in two to three months in crop-dependent agropastoral areas of Bay, Bakool, and Gedo between June and September if the below-average April to June *gu* rains end early or dry spells occur during critical crop development in May and June. Development of an early El Niño is likely to bring below-normal June to September 2026 rainfall across Ethiopia's Kiremt-producing areas, western Kenya, South Sudan, Sudan, and Karamoja in Uganda.

East Asia and the Pacific

Food security conditions remain uneven across East Asia and the Pacific, shaped by divergent import dependencies. Although near-record rice harvests across Cambodia, China, Indonesia, Thailand, and Viet Nam could provide a supply cushion, surging input costs are threatening the next planting cycle. Impact is most severe where recent shocks are overlapping with existing vulnerabilities. In Myanmar, food security has deteriorated as [food prices](#) have risen. Approximately 12.4 million people were facing crisis-level [food insecurity](#) (IPC Phase 3+) in May, and the figure is expected to climb to 20 million or more by mid-year. Extreme El Niño conditions may significantly reduce Malaysia's [rice production](#). In the Philippines, authorities warned in April that 15 provinces are at risk of severe [El Niño-induced drought](#) in the coming months, threatening national paddy output and staple food supply. [Rice output could decline by 20 to 50 percent](#). Papua New Guinea and the Solomon Islands are facing a double catastrophe of price shocks linked to the conflict in the Middle East and Cyclone Maila and now also the threat of El Niño-induced drought. Farmers in Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, and Thailand have seen farm profitability decline because of higher fertilizer and energy costs, which could affect rice planting decisions during the upcoming cropping season.

In Thailand, [severe drought conditions](#) are forecast to persist over the next three years. In contrast, rice market conditions have improved in Indonesia, where public rice reserves reached a record [5 million tonnes in April 2026](#). [Annual rice inflation](#) has moderated to 3.7 percent, indicating short-term price stabilization and better stock management. The country also seems to have excess stocks of fertilizer, which it is [considering exporting to the region](#).

Europe and Central Asia

Food and nutrition security in Europe and Central Asia remains broadly stable, but risks have intensified because of spillovers from the Middle East conflict. Although there is no evidence of widespread acute food insecurity deterioration, higher energy, fertilizer, logistics, and food costs are increasing pressure on poorer households, and continued vigilance on inflation, fertilizer availability, and transport costs will be essential. At the same time, tighter input markets and disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz are increasing production costs and global food prices, notably for cereals and vegetable oils in April 2026. Rising fertilizer prices may weigh on yields, even as shifting trade routes create opportunities for alternative corridors, [with Türkiye emerging as a strategic link between Europe and Asia](#).

Impacts vary across the region. Import-dependent countries in Central Asia, [the South Caucasus, and the Western Balkans](#) are most exposed to price transmission, and Türkiye and Ukraine face pressures from logistics and trade disruptions. Governments are responding with [duty liberalization](#), [subsidies](#) and [credit programs](#), [export restrictions](#), and broader fiscal support to sustain fertilizer use. [Strong grain exports from Kazakhstan and intraregional trade continue to support regional supply conditions](#).

Latin America and the Caribbean

Food and nutrition security in Latin America and the Caribbean remains uneven. [Strong harvests in major producers, including Brazil and Mexico](#), are increasing regional availability, but gains are not translating evenly into access, and significant vulnerabilities persist in Central America and the Caribbean. [High fuel and staple food prices continue to erode purchasing power](#): diesel prices in Guatemala City rose by about 33 percent between January and March 2026, and white maize prices in Tegucigalpa remained 39 percent above the five-year average. More than 33 million people are facing hunger, and 167 million are experiencing moderate or severe food insecurity.

Risks are rising from two directions. First, climate forecasts point to below-average rainfall in Central America during May to July 2026 and a likely El Niño later in the year, increasing drought risk in the Dry Corridor and northeastern Brazil. Second, the Middle East conflict is impacting fuel and fertilizer markets, raising transport and production costs.

Haiti remains the region's most severe hotspot, with about 6 million people projected to face Crisis-level food insecurity or worse through mid-2026, [driven by gang violence, economic collapse, high inflation, climate shocks, and import dependency](#).

Middle East and North Africa

The regional outlook is sharply divided; conflict drives severe food insecurity across the Middle East, and greater rainfall and robust cereal production ease supply pressures in parts of North Africa. Still, the subregion remains exposed to rising energy and fertilizer import costs if tensions escalate.

Conditions remain most severe in [Yemen](#), where about 18.3 million people are projected to be in IPC acute food insecurity phase 3 (Crisis) to 4 (Emergency) through September 2026; in [Syria](#), where more than 80 percent of households are food insecure, and 600,000 children under five face acute malnutrition; and in

[Lebanon](#), where 1.24 million people are projected to be in IPC 3+ through August 2026, and more than 80 percent of southern markets remain non-functional. [Gaza illustrates the severity of access constraints](#), with truck inflows still well below precrisis levels, leaving food stocks sufficient for only 10 to 14 days and creating a 50 percent gap in key staples. [Iraq](#) is experiencing renewed inflationary pressure, including on inputs, such as urea, which rose by approximately 19 percent in a single week in April 2026.

Morocco's cereal output rebounded to 9 million tonnes, covering about 75 percent of wheat needs, and Tunisia's harvest is projected to be 15 to 20 percent greater than the previous season.

South Asia

South Asia's food and nutrition security remains broadly stable in terms of aggregate food availability, but affordability is becoming more fragile as the Middle East conflict [raises fuel, freight, insurance, and fertilizer costs across food supply chains](#). The main risks are higher transport and input costs, tighter fertilizer markets, and renewed inflationary pressure on cereals and vegetable oils, which could intensify food price pressures during 2026. These effects will be uneven. India is better placed to absorb near-term shocks because cereal output reached record levels in 2025, and prospects for the 2026 wheat crop remain favorable, supported by procurement, public stocks, and input subsidies. In contrast, more-import-dependent economies such as Bhutan, Nepal, and Sri Lanka are more exposed to higher landed costs for food and agricultural inputs and to stronger pass-through to retail prices. Governments are responding using fertilizer procurement, subsidies, reserve management, and import diversification while also promoting use of more-resilient inputs such as organic inputs, bio- and nano-fertilizers, solar irrigation, and electric alternatives. Production prospects are mixed overall, with India's cereal outlook remaining strong but fertilizer and energy constraints threatening yields and seasonal planting elsewhere in the region.

West and Central Africa

Food and nutrition security conditions in West and Central Africa remain fragile despite favorable harvests and an increase in cereal supplies. Final estimates for the 2025/26 season show that regional cereal production [reached 80.4 million tonnes, about 4 percent above the previous season and 7 percent above the five-year average](#), supported by good rainfall across much of the Sahel. Markets are generally well supplied with local cereals and imported rice, helping reduce prices year on year in many countries. Millet, sorghum, and maize prices in several Sahelian markets [remained stable or declined in March and April 2026 and were significantly below year-earlier levels](#), thanks to good harvests, carryover stocks, and supportive policies.

Nevertheless, food insecurity remains widespread, and nearly [52.9 million people](#) are projected to face acute food and nutrition insecurity (IPC Phase 3 or worse) during the June to August 2026 lean season, especially in conflict-affected areas of the central Sahel, the Lake Chad Basin, and northeastern Nigeria.

The conflict in the Middle East is increasing concerns [about higher fuel, freight, and fertilizer costs in a region](#) that depends heavily on imported inputs and food. These pressures could affect the 2026/27 agricultural season by decreasing fertilizer affordability and increasing production costs. Pastoral conditions are also worsening in parts of the western and central Sahel because of pasture and water shortages, bushfires, and insecurity-related movement restrictions.

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